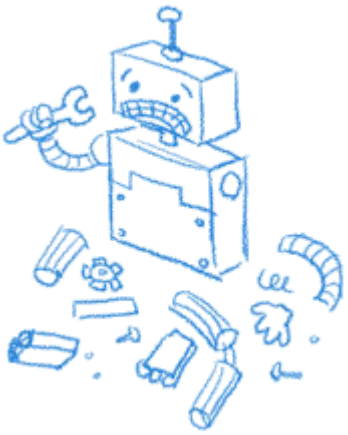
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STEELSTOWN PARISH

Parish Newsletter

THIRTIETH SUNDAY IN ORDINARY TIME • 25 OCTOBER 2026 • YEAR A

Gospel Reflection | Matthew 22:34–40

In today's Gospel, Jesus teaches that the greatest commandment is to love God wholeheartedly and to love our neighbour as ourselves. These two responsibilities are inseparable and form the foundation of Christian life.

Loving God involves more than religious practices such as prayer, worship, and Scripture reading. It means trusting Him in difficult times, remaining faithful through challenges, choosing what is right, and allowing Him to guide every aspect of our lives. Genuine love for God is shown not only in words but also in daily actions.

Our love for God becomes visible in how we treat others. We cannot truly love God while harming, judging, or refusing to forgive those around us. Instead, we are called to show compassion, kindness, patience, and mercy. Even simple acts such as listening, encouraging, forgiving, and helping those in need can become powerful expressions of God's love.

Jesus also calls us to recognise the dignity and worth of every person, including those who differ from us or disappoint us. True love does not ignore wrongdoing, but it speaks the truth with respect and sets boundaries without hatred.

The central message of this Gospel is that love must be at the heart of both our relationship with God and our relationship with others. Faith is not measured by religious knowledge or activities alone, but by whether it transforms us into more loving people. When love guides our thoughts, words, and actions, our lives become a living witness to God's presence in the world.

Prayer for the Week • May the Lord bless us with hearts open to love. May He help us to see Christ in one another and to bring kindness, hope, and compassion wherever we go.

Sunday Readings | 1 November – All Saints

First Reading: Revelation 7:2–4, 9–14 • Psalm: 24:1–2, 3–4, 5–6
Second Reading: 1 John 3:1–3 • Gospel: Matthew 5:1–12

Saints of the Coming Week

Tuesday: St Otteran, monk • Wednesday: St Simon and St Jude, Apostles
Thursday: St Colman of Kilmacduagh, bishop • Friday: St John of Capistrano, priest
Saturday: St Anthony Mary Claret, bishop

Prayer, Worship & Vocations

Pray for Vocations St Paul reminds the Thessalonians that it was "with the joy of the Holy Spirit" that they took to the Gospel. We pray for future priests of our diocese, that they will experience the joy of the Spirit as they read, live and preach the Good News of God's love.

Diocesan Vocations Holy Hours Tuesday 3 November and 1 December, 8–9 pm, following 7.30 pm Mass in St Columb's Church, Chapel Road, Waterside, Derry. Everyone welcome.

Considering a Vocation to the Priesthood? Meeting in Derry on Sunday 8 November at 4 pm. Contact Fr Pat O'Hagan, Diocesan Vocations Director: pgoh2111@gmail.com or (028) 7938 6259.

Praying for the Holy Souls Our Lady of Montligeon Prayer Group meets Wednesday 28 October, 12.30–1.30 pm, at Termonbacca, Derry. All welcome.

Annual Solemn Novena to Our Lady of Perpetual Help Nine Sundays before Christmas at Long Tower Church, Derry, 6 pm, beginning Sunday 25 October. Theme: "Make Me a Channel of Your Peace – Celebrating the 800th Jubilee Year of St Francis." Each night includes the Rosary, Novena prayers and petitions, a guest talk, Eucharistic Healing Ceremony and Benediction. All welcome, especially those in need of healing. Webcam: https://longtowerchurch.org/webcam/

Parish & Diocesan Events

6–8 NOV	**A Weekend Retreat with Sr Clare Crockett** Termonbacca, Derry. Prayer, reflection and an opportunity to learn more about Sr Clare. Contact: termonbaccderry@ocd.ie or facebook.com/TermonbaccaDerry/
15 NOV	**Omagh Charismatic Prayer Group – Golden Jubilee** Day of Prayer, Praise and Healing at Silverbirch Hotel, Omagh. Registration 9.30 am; concluding with afternoon Mass. Theme: "People of God's Delight" (Ps 149:4). Speaker: Fr John Keane. £40 including coffee and lunch. Book by 1 November: Evelyn 07876 411435 or Kathleen 07596 609041.
19 NOV	**The Columban Young Adults – Holy Hour & Meditation** 7 pm, Our Lady of Lourdes Church, Steelstown, Derry. For ages 18–35. Meditation by recently retired Bishop Donal McKeown, followed by Solemn Benediction and refreshments. New members welcome. Contact: columbanyoungadults@gmail.com.
20–22 NOV	**Abide Women's Conference** Great Northern Hotel, Bundoran. Speakers include Sarah Swafford, Fr Barry Braun, Fr Mark Wharton, Kimberlee WooLing, Danielle Noonan and the Nashville Dominicans. Mass celebrated by Bishop Fintan Gavin. Registration: Abide in His Love on Eventbrite.ie.
5 DEC	**St Patrick's, Dungannon – Charismatic Prayer Group Golden Jubilee** Servite Priory, Benburb, 11 am–3 pm, concluding with Mass. Theme: "Come to the water: all who are thirsty, Come." Everyone welcome.

Marriage & Family Life

ACCORD Derry – Marriage Preparation Courses In-person at the Everglades Hotel, Derry. Dates: 29–30 January, 19–20 February and 19–20 March 2027. Book at www.accordni.com.

Catholic Marriage Encounter Weekend St Mary's, Knock, Co. Mayo, Friday 9–Sunday 11 April 2027. Residential weekend for married couples, beginning Friday at 7.30 pm and ending Sunday at 4.30 pm. Online booking only: www.marriageencounter.ie.

Job Opportunity

Choir Director – St Eugene's Cathedral, Derry Experienced Choir Director sought for 10 hours per week to lead the cathedral choir and enhance worship through music. Application pack: (028) 7126 2302 or recruitment@derrydiocese.org. Completed applications to Personnel, Bishop's House, St Eugene's Cathedral, Derry, BT48 9AP, or by email, by noon on Thursday 12 November 2026. Derry Diocesan Trust is an Equal Opportunities Employer; applications from all communities welcome.

STEELSTOWN PARISH • Growing together in faith, hope and love.